Keep Increasing In Strength

Acts 9:20-25

Intro:

Last week, we observed Saul's conversion on the road to Damascus. We saw the incredible moment when the Lord revealed Himself to Saul and then sent Ananias to restore his sight and baptize him. In this week's passage, we will observe Saul's remarkable spiritual growth as he immediately begins living for Christ and fulfilling the purpose for which he was saved. We will examine two acts of obedience and one experience of opposition in Saul's life, and consider how God uses these things to strengthen us and help us grow as disciples of Christ.

V.19b-25

"Now for several days he was with the disciples who were at Damascus, and **immediately he began to proclaim Jesus** in the synagogues, *saying, "He is the Son of God."* **All those hearing him continued to be amazed**, and were saying, "Is this not he who in Jerusalem destroyed those who called on this name, and who had come here for the purpose of bringing them bound before the chief priests?" **But Saul kept increasing in strength** and confounding the Jews who lived at Damascus **by proving that this Jesus is the Christ**. When many days had elapsed, **the Jews plotted together to do away with him**, but their plot became known to Saul. They were also watching the gates day and night so t**hat they might put him to death**; but **his disciples** took him by night and let him down through an opening in the wall, lowering him in a large basket."

1. **Immediate Obedience** (V.20-22)

One of the first things that stands out in these verses is the phrase, "Immediately he began to proclaim Jesus." Saul immediately began living out the purpose for which Christ had saved and called him: to proclaim His name. He didn't wait for the perfect moment or make excuses; he simply obeyed. Saul understood that the very Jesus he had once persecuted was the Savior who had forgiven his sins and transformed his life, and now he was determined to make Him known. What is remarkable is that verse 22 tells us that Saul "kept increasing in strength." We should never underestimate the importance of immediate obedience in our spiritual growth. The more we put into practice what Christ has commanded us, rather than continually postponing obedience, the more opportunities we have to grow in our faith and maturity as His disciples.(Read: James 1:22–25)

2. **Opposition** (V.23-24)

As the narrative continues, we see that the once-persecutor now becomes the persecuted. The Jews begin plotting to kill Saul and do away with him, forcing him to flee Damascus. As we will see next week, Saul will eventually make his way to Jerusalem, where he will face opposition once again, this time even from within the church. Yet through it all, the Lord continues to work in his life. I firmly believe that one of the things God used to strengthen Saul spiritually was the opposition he faced. It is through opposition that we learn to trust God, rest in His promises, forgive those who wrong us, and truly love and exercise patience toward others. Opposition is an important part of our spiritual growth because it is through trials and tribulations that the Lord molds our hearts to become more like Christ. (Read James 1:2-4, Romans 5:3-5, 1 Peter 1: 6-7)

3. Making Disciples (V.25)

I find it very interesting that in verse 25, Luke refers to those who helped Saul escape as "his disciples," potentially suggesting that Saul was already actively making disciples himself. Although the passage doesn't explicitly tell us this, I firmly believe that investing in the spiritual lives of others is one of the ways God strengthens us as disciples of Christ. Making disciples is essential to our calling and plays an important role in our growth toward Christlikeness. Many times, as believers, we neglect this responsibility and focus only on our own spiritual growth, which can actually become counterproductive. Christ never intended for us to live the Christian life focused solely on ourselves. As we obey His command to make disciples, caring for others spiritually, teaching them His Word, encouraging them, and walking alongside them, the Lord also works in our own hearts, growing us in maturity, love, patience, humility, and Christlikeness. As we dedicate ourselves to helping others grow as disciples of Christ, we continue growing as disciples ourselves. (Read Proverbs 11:25, Hebrews 10:24–25, Ephesians 4:15–16, 1 Timothy 4:13-16)

Main Idea:

As believers, we should desire to keep increasing in spiritual strength day by day through the Spirit of Christ who dwells in us. Yet many times, we become stagnant in our faith because we neglect the very things God uses to grow us. If we desire to continue growing in Christlikeness, we must learn to walk in immediate obedience, faithfully carrying out our calling to proclaim Christ. We must also remember that we will face opposition in many forms, but rather than becoming discouraged, we should keep our eyes fixed on Christ and rejoice, knowing that God uses these trials to strengthen our faith and transform us more into His image. Lastly, we must never neglect our calling to make disciples, understanding that as we invest in the spiritual growth of others, the Lord is also growing us as disciples of Christ.

